



THE ISLAND OF BALI LIES IN THE INDONESIAN ARCHIPELAGO

BALINESE

LIFE ON PARADISE ISLAND



COMMUNITY LIFE

Family and community ties are one of the most important factors in Balinese life. All the families in a village worship a common ancestor—the village god—who binds the community together. Villages regularly organize festivals and participate in music and dancing.

FARMING RICE

Rice is grown on every piece of land that is accessible to water. Irrigation is difficult, but the Balinese have developed an elaborate system of canals, dams, bamboo pipes, and tunnels to control the water.



1 Watering fields

First the terraces and fields are filled to the brim with water, which makes the land look like giant mirrors reflecting the sky.



2 Planting seeds

When the earth has turned to mud, the seeds are sprinkled on the ground. They will grow into a thick green carpet.



3 Harvesting grain

As the grain ripens, the rice plants turn a golden color. Both men and women work hard to collect the rice at harvesttime.

Rice culture

According to Balinese legend, the island originally only grew sugar cane. Then, out of pity for the human race, the God of fertility and water came to Earth and delivered rice. Rice to the Balinese is therefore a gift from God and is treated with great respect. From planting to harvest, the rice is watched, tended, and worshipped.

Men carry the rice in two baskets on their shoulder and the women carry it in baskets on their heads.



THE RICE RITE

The Balinese perform many rituals and ceremonies to make the rice grow well. They pray for enough water, and the prevention of pollution to the land, and perform rituals to keep thieves, such as mice, away.

